

Credible consensus among strangers

A jury for funding the research commons

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Two questions

Did they ship it? Evidence can answer that. How much does it matter? That is a judgment under a policy. A credible consensus is a candidate answer that a community can act on.

The game in five lines

1. Read one published policy.
2. Score each nominee alone; seal the score.
3. Open the scores together.
4. Inside the band, share the reward by closeness to the centre.
5. Outside the band, forfeit more the farther you land from it.

What the design is meant to do

Pay for coherence with the room under one public policy: a Keynesian beauty contest with the judging criteria written down. Sealed scores leave jurors only the prompt and the evidence in common, so with nothing to copy, a juror's best forecast of the hidden centre is their own careful reading. That is the bet: paying for closeness to an unseen centre pays for honest reading. It rests on a concrete prompt, jurors who know the field or recuse, and no coordination outside the game. It does not prove that honest scoring always wins, or that agreement alone makes a judgment credible.

The centre and band are derived from the same jury. The workshop uses points and equal seats; random draws weighted by stake and appeals belong to the proposed full design.

The shared prompt

How much does this nominee's completed and maintained work underpin how research is done, shared and kept, now?

Docket: Inkscape, Linux, PDF, LaTeX, arXiv, NumPy.

Five objections

Objection	Proposed defence
Herding	Sealed scores hide other jurors' readings until they can no longer change them.
Vote buying	A proof shown to a buyer can be reported for a bounty, making verification risky.
Collusion	Random draws weighted by stake, forfeits and appeals to larger juries are proposed. No safe threshold is established.
Vague policy	Worked anchors and recusal help strangers apply the same prompt.
Fake identities	In the proposed design, stake weighs seats; concentrated stake remains a concern.

Where it fits

Review panels, grant programmes and community funds: a community sets the policy; a jury supplies scores to inform its decisions.

Try, read, stay in touch



The room



The working paper



Mailing list

Working paper:
doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20543760

Arrow, the first funded round of this design, runs at Octant in early 2027: an invited jury of domain experts scores a real docket under a published policy.
octant.build